



Troubleshooting Methodology

Use this when: a ticket lands and you want a repeatable path from "it's broken" to fixed, verified and documented.

CompTIA A+ V15 · Network+ N10-009
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The 6 steps (CompTIA A+)

Network+ uses 7: step 4 is split into "plan" and "implement or escalate"



Step 1: ask the user

- 🕒 When did it start? Did it ever work?
- 🔄 What changed: update, new device, moved desk?
- 📄 Exact error text or a screenshot?
- 👤 Just you, or others too? Other devices?
- 🔄 Can you show me the steps?

Step 2: question the obvious

- ☐ Power, cable, Wi-Fi on?
- ☐ Restarted (really)?
- ☐ Updates pending?
- ☐ Caps Lock / keyboard layout?
- ☐ Right account / tenant?
- ☐ Disk or mailbox full?
- ☐ Date & time correct?
- ☐ Service outage page?

Ways to find the cause

Bottom-up	OSI L1 → L7: cable, link, IP, app
Top-down	Start at the app when the network looks fine
Divide & conquer	Start in the middle: ping the gateway
Compare	Diff against a working device or user
One change	Change one thing, test, then the next

⚠ CAUTION Back up user data before reimaging, resetting profiles or replacing disks.

Escalate with

- ☐ Impact: who, how many
- ☐ What you tried + result
- ☐ Priority / SLA clock
- ☐ Steps to reproduce
- ☐ Logs, screenshots
- ☐ Best contact time

Talk to the user

- ✓ Say what you'll do next and when you'll update them
- ✓ Skip jargon; repeat the issue back in their words
- ✓ Never blame the user; thank them for the details

Step 6: ticket note template

Symptom: Outlook won't connect, 3 users, since 09:10
Cause: expired password on shared mailbox
Fix: reset via admin portal, re-signed in
Verified: user sent test mail 09:42
Prevent: added expiry alert

⚠ DANGER Suspect malware or a breach? Stop. Disconnect from the network, don't wipe, escalate to security. Verify identity before any password reset.

Set priority

example: follow your SLA

	URGENCY HIGH	MEDIUM	LOW
IMPACT HIGH	P1	P2	P3
MEDIUM	P2	P3	P4
LOW	P3	P4	P4

REMEMBER Can't reproduce it? You can't prove it's fixed
 Escalate early, with what you tried and the evidence

- Tell the user what you're doing and an ETA
- Close the ticket only after the user confirms